A Brief History of AI, 1943–2026

Breakthroughs, two AI winters, and the deep learning boom.

1943–1955 Foundations

1943 — First neuron model
McCulloch and Pitts show simple artificial neurons can compute logic.

1950 — Turing Test
Alan Turing asks whether machines can think and proposes a test.

1956–1973 Birth of AI

1956 — Dartmouth workshop
John McCarthy and others adopt the name "artificial intelligence."

1958 — Perceptron and Lisp
Rosenblatt's trainable neural network; McCarthy's AI language.

1966 — ELIZA
Weizenbaum's chatbot, the first of its kind.

1973 — Lighthill Report
UK review says AI has not delivered; funding is cut.

1974–1980 AI WINTER I

Cause: Overhyped promises, weak computers, little data.

Impact: Funding and interest drop; neural networks sidelined.

1980–2011 Expert systems and learning

1980 — Expert systems boom
Rule-based programs spread through industry.

1986 — Backpropagation
Rumelhart, Hinton and Williams popularize how to train multi-layer networks.

1987–1993 AI WINTER II

Cause: Expert systems were costly and brittle; Lisp machine market collapsed.

Impact: Companies failed and funding fell again.

1997 — Deep Blue beats Kasparov
IBM's computer defeats the world chess champion.

2006 — Cloud and GPUs
AWS launches cloud computing; NVIDIA opens GPUs to general computing.

2009 — ImageNet
Fei-Fei Li's large labeled image dataset.

2011 — Watson wins Jeopardy!
IBM's system beats human champions.

2012–2019 Deep learning revolution

2012 **AlexNet**
Trained on GPUs, it wins ImageNet with 15.3% error vs 26.2% for second place.

2016 **AlphaGo**
DeepMind beats Go champion Lee Sedol 4 to 1.

2017 **Transformer**
Google's architecture behind modern language models.

2020–2026

Generative AI era

2020 **GPT-3**
OpenAI's 175-billion-parameter language model.

2022 **ChatGPT**
Launches Nov 30 and reaches about 100 million users in two months.

2023 **GPT-4 and the model race**
OpenAI, Anthropic (Claude), Meta and Google compete.

2024 **Nobel Prizes for AI**
Hinton and Hopfield (Physics); Hassabis and Jumper (Chemistry).

2025 **Reasoning models**
OpenAI o3 and DeepSeek R1 bring step-by-step reasoning.

2026 **Constant releases**
New frontier models arrive every week or two.